To be clear, this is not a book about whether what the BJP stands for is right or wrong for India or whether Hindu nationalism, as opposed to Hindu traditionalism, in a Hindu-majority democracy is good or bad. Nor is it about the pros and cons of cultural nationalism vis-à-vis territorial nationalism. It is the story of how the BJP won India in electoral battlefields. It is about why it won (or did better than earlier) in more elections than it lost (or performed poorly in) since 2014. It answers the question of why Narendra Modi remained India's most popular electoral leader until mid-2021, at the time of writing, despite a below-par economy, and how the BJP did it.

In a deeply polarised polity divided between those who oppose the BJP, and compare its rise to something like the early rise of the 'Nazis' in Germany,[13] and those who welcome it as a vital Hindu cultural corrective to the cultural foundations of the nation, and where television news channels only shout to the converted on either side and social media is deeply split into echo chambers, this book is a non-partisan, empirical and evidence-based study. Such a method and approach to studying the BJP has never been more necessary. Unless facts are assessed and sifted, rational debate is not possible. *The New BJP* aims to shed fresh light on the modes of political power in India, the mechanics of the BJP's election triumphs, the role of technology in politics, how the party won power nationally and what this portends for Indian politics.

I have deliberately chosen to set aside personal value judgements and my own opinions on the pros and cons of 'secularism' versus 'Hindu nationalism' as a guiding philosophy for India. These ideas do appear throughout this book in the manner in which they were deployed by political parties, how they were contested by politicians, how their meanings and messaging changed over time and what they stand for today. My purpose is not to show whether one idea of India is superior to the other. That normative battle of ideas is for other books, political theorists, lawyers, constitutional experts, politicians or their proxy pamphleteers on both sides, wider civil society and the Indian citizens to continuously debate and contest.

Within these pages, I have a very specific purpose: to investigate, enquire and uncover why large sections of India agreed